

Polyphony

Literally meaning “many voices,” polyphony is a musical device in which several melodic lines are woven together. The parts are independent and equally important, although they tend to imitate one another. Known from the Middle Ages, polyphony reached the height of its popularity in 16th century choral music.

▽ “Amen”

In this setting of “Amen,” each of the three voices enter in turn with a similar pattern of four notes—a rising fourth followed by two downward steps.

Soprano

Alto

Bass

A - men, a - - - men, a - - - men.

A cappella

A cappella means “in the manner of the chapel” because it originally described church music. It now refers to several voices singing together without accompaniment. Their music may be unison, homophonic, or polyphonic. While most a cappella choirs use all four voices—soprano, alto, tenor, and bass—barbershop quartets are all male.

▽ “Sing We and Chant It”

This attractive Baroque a cappella piece by Thomas Morley can be sung by five solo voices, or a choir.

Sop. I

Sop. II

Alto

Tenor

Bass

Sing we and chant it, while love doth grant it,

Melody and accompaniment

Texture is crucial when setting words for a solo melody with instrumental accompaniment. If the piano part is too thickly chordal, or the accompanying instruments too densely orchestrated, the soloist will be difficult to hear. Composers can avoid this by creating contrasting textural patterns, and avoiding notes in the range of the solo.

▽ Mozart's Clarinet Quintet

In this extract, the accompanying string quartet plays a waltzlike chordal accompaniment beneath the soloist's lyrical melody.

Clarinet in A

Violin I

Violin II

Viola

Cello

Chord I

Chord ii°₅

Chord V⁷